
UNIT 6 PRINT MEDIA IN INDIA

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6.0 INTRODUCTION

In the previous unit you have learnt about the history of mass communication. In this unit you will be learning about development of print media in India. You know well that media influences both politics and economics of a society. As such, knowledge of media scene will help you to have a better understanding of the contemporary India.

Newspapers, magazines, books, comics etc. are the main print media you all are well familiar with. All these are important in today's world as they continue to reflect and mould the priorities of the society despite the availability of new media. In this unit, we will learn the brief history, growth and the factors affecting the operation of print media in the contemporary Indian society.

6.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

At the end of this unit you will be able to:

- describe the features of mass communication media;

- explain the role of mass media in society;
- explain the broad policy framework of print media;
- describe the history and evolution of print media; and
- explain the challenges faced by contemporary print media.

6.2 MASS COMMUNICATION- DEFINITION

We may define mass communication as a process whereby mass-produced messages are transmitted to large number of people, spread over and not at one place, heterogeneous and anonymous masses of receivers. By heterogeneous we mean people who are different from each other on account of age, gender, education, income, profession, residence, location, region, language, religion and so on and so forth. By anonymous we mean that the individuals receiving the messages are generally strangers to one another and also to the sources of those messages. The messages have been sent “to whom it may concern”. Be that as it may, to make mass communication more effective, segmentation of mass audience is done keeping with various considerations to make mass communication more focused and targeted.

6.3 MASS MEDIA AND SOCIETY

Mass Media play an important role in our day to day life. To know the cricket score you watch television, listen to radio or check your mobile updates. To know what have been the major developments in the country and the world you read newspaper or go to news websites. For entertainment you watch films, play games on mobiles or computers, read novels, books and magazines or watch television. Newspaper, magazine, books, radio, television, and film are mass media. We all are familiar with these mass media and are exposed to these mass media on a daily basis.

So, what do the mass media do in society? They give us scores and running commentary on our favorite games as they are played, inform us about the environment in which we live in the form of news and commentary about political developments, trouble spots, major events, accidents etc. Through mass media we come to know about the floods in Jammu and Kashmir, cyclone in Odisha or Indo-US nuclear deal. 24x7 television news channels bring news as news breaks and follow the news story as it unfolds and develops. The mass media track inflation and report economic developments. They analyse for us the current events. They sell goods and services.

The mass media set our agenda of work and leisure time activities. The contents of mass media are discussed in homes, coffee shops and at the workplaces. In the process the media keep us informed about the environment we live in. They influence our perceptions about various issues and personalities and shape public opinion and help in democratic functioning of our society. The mass media makes us laugh, cry, create drama, bring music and entertainment. In short, through mass media we communicate with the masses and sustain mass society.

Today, it is difficult to imagine normal social life without the newspaper in the morning, mobile phone or TV. In our day to day existence, media and society

are intimately linked and are interdependent realities of modern life. As such, in order to understand contemporary India, we need to understand contemporary media scene in India.

6.4 BROAD MEDIA POLICY FRAMEWORK

The importance of print media was realised during the course of freedom struggle itself. As such, after Independence broad policy framework guided the development, growth and use of print media. These include:

6.4.1 Freedom of Expression

As India opted for parliamentary democracy based on universal adult franchise, freedom of press was considered an essential element of democracy in the country. Although, the Indian Constitution has no express provision which specifically provides for freedom of the Press as such, however, the **“Right to Freedom of Speech and Expression”** provided under the Article 19(1) (a) of the Constitution as part of our Fundamental Rights and have been interpreted to include freedom to publish newspapers without any governmental interference subject to only reasonable restrictions that have been provided Article 19 (2). Only such restrictions can be imposed as are reasonable and are in the interest of sovereignty and integrity of India. Later in 1990s this interpretation was extended to air waves also to include electronic media. Free exchange of ideas and free debate are considered as essential part of the democratic functioning of government. *(You will be learning in detail about ‘Freedom of Press’ under Press Laws in another unit.)*

6.4.2 Concern about Nation Building and Development

Along with providing for “Freedom of Expression” the leadership in free India was concerned about making use of mass media and all other means of public education for promoting the unity and integrity of the nascent nation state and informing, educating and mobilising the people and seeking their willing participation in political and social development of the country. Like mixed economy approach towards national development, in information and broadcasting sectors also a mixed approach was adopted. While the press was free and largely in private hands except the requirement of registration of titles, foreign news agencies like Reuter, AFP etc were restricted and could provide their services to Indian news agencies like Press Trust of India (PTI) and United News of India (UNI). Broadcasting and telecommunication were retained as central government monopoly. Film production again was in private hands but public exhibition of films was subject to certification / clearance by the representative of the central government.

In India this concern about reaching people, communicating with them and equipping them with new skills was emphasised in the First Five Year Plan itself which provided the blue print for country’s planned development. It said: “A widespread understanding of the priorities which govern the Plan will enable each person to relate his or her role to the larger purpose of the nation as a whole. All available methods of communication have to be developed and the people approached through the written and spoken word no less than through radio, film, song and drama. Above all, steps have to be taken to provide literature and information for

the people in simple language and on scale equal to the need of the country”. Such a broad policy framework guided the development and growth of media in India till 1991 when a major policy shift took place leading to liberalisation and globalisation and ushering in the Information Technology revolution in the country. As a result, mass media scene dramatically changed with exponential growth and diversity.

Today, the mass media in India is free and is largely in private hands. Any citizen can bring out a newspaper or a magazine and publish what he/she chooses without obtaining any prior permission from any authority subject only to the responsibility before the law of the land for what he/ she would choose to publish. To publish a newspaper or a magazine the only requirements under the Press and Registration of Books Act of 1867 are registration certificate and declaration and printing legibly on it the name of the printer, the place of printing, the name of publisher and the place of publication.

But in case of Radio, Television and telecommunication the Central Government had the monopoly until 1991 when the Freedom of Expression, the Fundamental Right given in the Constitution, was interpreted by the Supreme Court of India to extend it to airwaves as well. With liberalisation and globalisation in 1990s the electronic media and telecommunication were also opened to private sector. As a consequence, today mobile phone is a common sight and we have many private TV channels and FM radio stations as well. It may be noted that though we have many TV news channels, still broadcasting of news on radio continues to be the monopoly of the central government.

6.4.3 Commerce and Entertainment

Commerce and entertainment are the other two important features of mass media. Besides providing information and education, the mass media are the major sources of entertainment. To attract and retain their audience, the mass media have to provide even information and education in an interesting and entertaining manner. Moreover, to recover the cost of production and distribution and make some profit, the mass media have to depend upon revenue generated through advertisement. The advertisement revenue depends upon readership, listenership and viewership of newspaper, radio and TV. As such, although providing information, education and entertainment are the primary functions of mass media, the promotion of commercial interests through advertising and marketing are becoming the major driving force in media operations. At times ‘quality’ and ‘contents’ are sacrificed in favour of advertisement revenue. Often sensationalisation of news and events is also resorted to increase circulation and TRPs to promote commercial interests. As a result, the mass media have increasingly become major infotainment business industries.

Realising that mass media play important role in our day to day life and ‘freedom of expression’ as provided in the Constitution of India as the basic value that propels and guides media operations, we will now discuss in detail the growth and development of different mass media so as to have a better understanding of contemporary India.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your Answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. What are the provisions in the Indian Constitution with regard to Freedom of Press?

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Activity – 1

How much time did you spent yesterday in reading newspaper, listening to radio and watching TV? Write the date_____ and the day

_____of the weekName of the Newspaper_____

_____Time spent reading the newspaper (in minutes)

Internet

Name of the Website

Time spent (in minutes)

i)

i)

ii)

ii)

iii)

iii)

TV

Name of the Channels

Time spent on Watching (in minutes)

i)

i)

ii)

ii)

iii)

iii)

6.5 PRESS

6.5.1 Pre-Independence Press

The Beginning: The Press has had its fair share of trials and tribulations in its evolution in India. The first weekly print venture '*Bengal Gazette*' was started by James Augustus Hickey on 29 January 1780. His newspaper primarily published slanderous news against the East India Company, especially the Governor-General, Warren Hastings in the garb of freedom of expression. Soon some more newspapers began to be published in Calcutta, Madras and Bombay. In Madras the first newspaper, *Madras Courier* appeared in 1785 and four years later Bombay's first newspaper, *Bombay Herald* was published.

As these newspapers largely catered to British residents and reported about activities of the East India Company, their circulation was small. Press laws did not exist and publishers were not free to print news as per their discretion. There were some innovations such as letter to the editors, advertisements as well as reporting on fashion and social issues.

6.5.2 Press during Freedom Struggle

The first half of the nineteenth century was characterised by proliferation of newspapers, especially in Indian languages. These papers put up a resistance against strict and unfair government regulations.

Many Indian elites also became editors and publishers in different parts of the country. Their circulation was still in thousands only still these newspapers became vehicles of social reforms, information, contacts and social awakening. It was believed that keeping an eye on the language newspapers could have revealed about the rebellion and appropriate measures could have been taken.

Raja Rammohan Roy, the social reformer, journalist and freedom fighter from Bengal started the Calcutta Journal and followed it up with Sambad Kaumudi and Mirat-Ul-Akhbar. The first Hindi language newspaper, *Uddant Martand* was published by Pt. Jugal Kishore Sukool on a weekly basis in the year 1826. Printing presses were sealed, newsprint was seized and many editors were jailed. The period after the first struggle for independence called for tighter regulations for the Indian language press.

There was significant expansion in the nationalist press near the end of the 19th century. The Marathi weekly *Kesari* and English weekly *Mahratta* were brought out by Bal Gangadhar Tilak in 1880.

Tilak was a not just a nationalist but also a true social reformer. He stressed that newspapers should expose social conditions that need to be improved. For him, the newspaper was also a means of political emancipation.

Mathur (2013) wrote that the anger and unrest against the British was at its peak in the early part of the 20th century. The powerful writings by Mahatma Gandhi also influenced the public. *Young India* and *Harijan* were able to amass huge readership and become vehicles of freedom struggle. He wrote with conviction and passion. His writings were simple, clear and powerful. Gandhi Ji published the newspapers to arouse feelings for 'Swaraj' as well as offer a platform to express the feelings of the people.

Gandhi Ji is known as a prolific journalist who could sway public opinion through his writings. This can be understood easily by the fact that even though his newspapers did not accept advertisements, they could survive through subscriptions. They became instruments for spreading his ideas amongst the public. His stand on the national movement was very well represented through his writings. Therefore, his newspapers garnered good readership.

Many popular leaders of the time took a cue from Gandhi Ji and took up journalism as a means to reach out to the people. They joined the fray as editors and publishers. With their missionary zeal, they used their weeklies or dailies for social reform, education and national awakening. The journalism of this era was known for its missionary zeal towards the cause of Indian independence (Mathur, 2013).

In the hands of Gandhi, Nehru, Tilak and many others, these newspapers became instruments of freedom struggle against the British rule in India.

6.5.3 Press in Independent India

An all pervasive euphoria prevailed after Independence marking the end of foreign rule after a long and arduous freedom struggle. The press was no exception. There was great enthusiasm to express national urges and aspirations, and to build a strong independent India. The press was part of, and at the same time, vehicle of such urges and aspirations. The press was supposed to play a part in nation building and support the development efforts by the government. In fact, such was the importance placed on the press, that it came to be called as the fourth estate—the first three being the Legislature, Executive and the Judiciary.

The first Prime Minister, Jawahar Lal Nehru, also contributed a lot towards development of the press. He pressed for a free and fair press. He had famously remarked that, “I would rather have a completely free Press, with all dangers involved in the wrong use of that freedom than a suppressed or regulated Press”. As a result, the Press was significantly deregulated after India gained independence.

Thus, the Press in India is free, vibrant and vigilant. It fearlessly exposes the wrongs in our society and polity. It zealously guards its own freedom and brooks no restrictions or regulations from the government.

The Indian press is largely in private hands and is commercial enterprise from the days of its pioneers. Numerically individual ownership accounts for majority of the newspaper titles but their circulation is limited. On the other hand, small number of companies (about 75) own major daily newspapers with multi editions and magazine accounting for over 80 per cent of the circulation.

6.5.4 Mission to Profession

Indian independence brought along changes in the role of the press. Earlier, they were connecting popular leaders to the public by acting as a ‘views-paper’ and helped them in gaining support for their initiatives. It became a powerful instrument of freedom struggle. This changed after independence as the reverence for leaders gave way to a more watchful attitude about their decisions. Although the popularity of the leaders continued unabated as they had formed a bond with the masses during the course of the struggle, the press quickly adopted the role of a watchdog.

However, government felt a need to regulate the newspaper industry post independence. Therefore, First Press Commission of India was constituted in 1952 to help newspapers maintain their independence, raise the standards through a code of conduct and maintain high professional standards as well as high standards of public taste. On the basis of their recommendations, the Press Council Act, 1965 was passed and the Press Council of India was established in 1966.

Gradually, strict regulations for press resulted into the new trend of ‘hand-out’ journalism where reportage was restricted to official version of events handed out for publication. There wasn’t much scope for critical analysis of the actions of the government even as political rivals received newspaper coverage. Nehru paid attention to the critical editorials and cartoons even when they were critical of him. However, the press was refrained from publishing any major expose during his time with the exception of the Indo-China war in 1962.

The press bitterly criticized Nehru's defense preparedness and Krishna Menon, the then Defense Minister, became the first major victim of the press attack in free India (Mathur, 2013).

6.5.5 Emergency period: A Dark Chapter

In subsequent years, things changed rather drastically. The press was not as kind to Indira Gandhi, who dominated the Indian political scene for nearly 18 years, as it was to Nehru. She viewed the press with guile and suspicion. Such a mutual distrust led to the press taking up the adversary role vigorously and the rulers using both carrot and sticks to tame the press failing that imposed national emergency and censorship on the press in 1975 which lasted for about one and a half year. That the "journalists crawled when they were merely asked to bend" is a sad commentary on the profession as a whole during emergency days. With the end of emergency and lifting of censorship in 1977 gave boost to growth of the press in India, especially the news magazines. As a result, the Second press commission was constituted in 1978 that stressed upon building cordial relations among government and the press.

Exposing the failures of the Government and those in public life is an age-old and well recognised function of the press. It is true of the Indian press as well. However, with the exposure of the Bhagalpur blinding case in Sunday, the English weekly in 1979 resulting in the public uproar, began a new phase in Indian journalism. Some public-spirited lawyers took up the case with the Supreme Court giving a new turn to the watchdog function of the press. Since then the investigative journalism in India has covered many milestones and in the process many misdeeds of individuals and the governments have come to the public light.

As a consequence, the conflict between libertarian philosophy and social responsibility theory of the press, which together guided and molded the functioning of the press in India over the years, is now becoming sharper. There is no denying the fact that journalism as a profession has come of age in India. From being a mission, it has graduated into being a competitive and market-driven industry. Promotion and hard selling have become necessary. Skills and strategies of selling news and newspapers have become essential. Catchy headlines, attractive layout are necessary for sale and promotion some time even at the cost the 'contents' the main substance of the press - the news.

In 1980s and 1990s the revolution in communication technologies and opening of Indian economy with liberalisation and globalisation transformed the press in India rapidly. Computerisation, enormously improved telecommunication services, satellite, mobile phones, latest printing technologies, digital cameras all contributed to introduction of colour and the rapid expansion of the press in the country. Simultaneously, the perception about press changed. Press came to be viewed as an industry and a business and the newspaper as a product to be marketed and sold just as any other product like soaps and toothpastes. The proprietors of many a newspapers and magazines started giving preference to advertisers and marketers over the editors and news reporters. The institution of the editor declined.

Be that as it may, newspaper is more than a product to be marketed and sold to consumers. It affects minds, thoughts, values and culture of the readers. So, it is much more than being a product though economic viability of newspaper is essential and profit making is also legitimate as it is a commercial activity.

This was also a period of rapid technological advancements helping in first hand news gathering from distant places including remote areas with speed or simply downloading from the internet services, transmitting, editing, colour printing and delivering the final product- to the readers all over the country. The result is multi-editions of major newspapers, special supplements, segmentations and zoning giving rise to regional and district news editions.

The increased capacity to handle large amount of news daily made it possible for newspapers to take upon some of the features of magazine journalism as well. Consequently, some of the news magazines were closed down like, *The Illustrated Weekly of India*, *Dharumyug*, *Sunday* etc; while many special interest magazines like *Business India*, *Business World* and *Business Today*; film magazines like, *Filmfare*, *Stardust*, *Cine Blitz*; computer and technology magazines like *Computers Today* and *Telematics*; became more popular. To meet the growing interest in economic developments and the market, most daily newspapers both English and other Indian languages, added special business sections. Not only that the number of exclusive business and economic dailies increased and became popular.

The coming of many 24x7 television news channels posed some threats to newspaper industry but soon it adjusted to new environment. Television news channels may have become the prime sources of hot spot news and breaking of news stories, the newspapers continue to be the providers of the details of the news stories and analysis. The newspapers started giving more features and soft news stories and photo features and what is popularly known as Page-3 journalism came into vogue. It would not be wrong to say that television news is like the appetizer and newspapers are like the main menus for satisfying the hunger to know as to what is happening daily in the world around us.

6.5.7 Contemporary Challenges

Today, the press is accused of indulging in paid news which means publishing paid features or news articles in exchange for money. These are different from advertisements since they look like normal news features. This is an ethical violation as readers may not be able to differentiate between news and paid news. Other key issues the press faces today are violation of the Majithia wage board recommendations on salaries of working journalists, poor ethical standards and spreading yellow journalism or sensational stories. However, not all changes are bad. New experiments have added colour and made newspapers more interesting. The newspaper apps and e-papers have allowed people to access online editions of newspapers from their cities despite being thousands of kilometers away.

The improved presentation styles, better use of colours, pictures, design and graphics due to rapid growth of digital media, fast and convenient editing through computers and content customisation have made it a very dynamic industry.

However, commercial considerations have at times taken precedence over professional propriety leading to sensationalisation of news presentations and commentary to boost the sales, bringing a bad name to the noble profession of keeping the public informed about the environment in which we live and damages the credibility of the fourth pillar of democracy. To check such tendencies self regulation by the press itself is preferred to any outside interference from outside.

The designated body to do this is the Editors Guild of India.

6.5.8 Ever Expanding Press, Books

Thus, notwithstanding the growth of television, the press continues to expand and grow in India. In 1950s only 240 daily newspapers were published in India. This number rose to 2,856 dailies in 1990 and to 5364 daily newspapers in 2000. In March 2018, there were more than a lakh publications registered with the RNI.

In 1993, the total number of newspapers and periodicals published was 35,595 which has gone up to 62,550 in 2006 which indicative of substantial growth of the press since 1990s. As per the 55th annual report of Registrar of Newspapers of India, we have a total of 82,237 registered periodicals of which 32,793 were in Hindi. English came second with 11,478 newspapers and periodicals. The total circulation of newspapers increased to 32,92,04,841 from 30,88,16,563 copies in 2009-10.

The publication of books in India dates back to 1566 when first printing press was established in Goa. Today, publishing books is a flourishing business. Advances in marketing and technology have propelled India's book publishing industry forward into a rapid and glorious expansion. Today, books are available in local translations, in electronic forms as e-books, in audio form as audio books and in picture form as graphic books. Nielsen Book Scan estimated that 13 million books worth Rs 3.28bn were sold in the year 2011 covering over 286,455 separate titles. In the end of the year 2013, magazine industry was valued at INR14 billion. Niche magazines targeting a specific audience like magazines on photography, travel, lifestyle, Bollywood, architecture, sports, business etc. are performing the best.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your Answers.
2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. What was the role played by press in pre independence period?

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2. How did Gandhiji define the objectives of press?

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3. Mention some famous social and political figures who also worked as journalists in pre-independence period along with names of their publications.

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4. What were the main responsibilities of the press in post independence era?

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5. How have technological changes impacted the press?

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5. What are the problems faced by the press in today's time?

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Activity – 2 Find out the latest

Circulation figure for the Press as whole _____

Circulation figure for the English daily Newspapers _____

Circulation figure for the Hind dailies _____

Circulation figure for the dailies in other Indian languages _____

6.6 LET US SUM UP

Mass Media in India have played an important role in the development of our country as informers, educators and entertainers. Each media has contributed in its own way towards development of the nation at different times. The print media was the first major medium that reached the masses apart from folk media. Thus, print media (books, newspapers, magazines, journals etc.) has a long and important history. It was primarily centered around organising masses against the British and played a key role in mobilising support for the national independence movement. In early days, British citizens started publishing the newspapers to vent their anger against the government. Later, the freedom fighters used them to connect with masses, organize revolts, remove superstition and unite the nation.

The British had to place restrictions on the growth of the press as it became a threat to them. Many freedom fighters including Mahatma Gandhi brought out their own papers. The constitutional provisions about Freedom of Speech and Expression helped the newspapers immensely in newly independent India. The newspapers at the time focused on nation building and assisting the government

to bring about development. They went to the extent of openly and fearlessly criticising the actions and policies of the government. A Press Council was constituted to safeguard the interests of the press.

In the 1970's, the imposition of emergency by Mrs. Indira Gandhi, the then Prime Minister, caused irreparable loss of reputation and quality to the press. In some cases, censorship was imposed and papers had to get prior approvals for publishing stories. Things started improving with the coming of liberalisation in 1990's. Newsprint was subsidised and companies from outside were allowed to invest in the Indian printing world. Cable TV gave stiff competition to newspapers as sources of news and as a result, the quality of news presentation improved.

6.7 FURTHER READINGS

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6.8 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. The Indian Constitution has no express provision for freedom of the Press, however, there is **“Right to Freedom of Speech and Expression”** provided under the Article 19(1) (a) as part of our Fundamental Rights. It has been interpreted to include freedom to publish newspapers without any governmental interference subject to reasonable restrictions provided in Article 19

Check Your Progress 2

1. During its early days, the press in India was managed by British. They used it to publish about their dissatisfaction with the government. Later many

freedom fighters and social reformers used the press for nationalist causes. It was a vehicle of social and economic reform, political emancipation. It was also an instrument for national unification.

2. According to Gandhiji the main objectives of the press were:-
 - to understand the popular feelings and give expression
 - to arouse among people certain desirable sentiments, and
 - to fearlessly expose defects in public life
3. The personalities are
 - Raja Rammohan Roy - *Sambad Kaumudi* and *Mirat-Ul-Akhbar*,
 - Bal Gangadhar Tilak - *Kesari* (Marathi) and *Mahratta* (English)
 - Mahatma Gandhi - *Young India* and *Harijan*
4. Immediately after independence, there was great enthusiasm to express national urges and aspirations, and to build a strong independent India. The press was part of, and at the same time, vehicle of such urges and aspirations. The press was supposed to play a part in nation building and support the development efforts by the government. It was also expected to perform the role of a watchdog.
5. Computerisation, improved telecommunication services, satellite, mobile phones, latest printing technologies, digital cameras all contributed to introduction of colour and the rapid expansion of the press in the country. Press came to be viewed as an industry and a business and the newspaper as a product to be marketed and sold just as any other product like soaps and toothpastes. The proprietors of many a newspapers and magazines started giving preference to advertisers and marketers